

Junior AFL Small-Sided Games (SSGs)

This document outlines a series of small-sided games designed to improve game sense, decision-making, and technical skill execution. These drills move beyond basic skill repetitions and place players in "game-like" scenarios where they must solve tactical problems under pressure.

Under 10s: Development & Game Sense

The following drills focus on introducing tactical awareness, spatial positioning, and finding "outside" options while maintaining core skill execution.

1. The Exit Strategy

- **Objective:** To teach players to look for a "release" option immediately after winning a contested ball at a stoppage.
- **Setup:**
 - A 20m x 20m central square.
 - Two "target" players (one from each team) stationed 30m outside the square on opposite wings.
- **Execution:**
 - Start with a 3v3 or 4v4 contest inside the central square.
 - The coach balls the ball up in the center to simulate a stoppage.
 - The team that wins the clearance must perform at least one clean handball within the square before attempting to "exit."
 - The goal is to deliver a well-weighted kick to their target player waiting outside the zone.
- **Coaching Points:**
 - **Vision:** Encourage the "inside" player to lift their head immediately after receiving the handball.
 - **Communication:** The "outside" target must call loudly and lead into space to provide a clear option.

2. The 4v3 Overload

- **Objective:** To practice exploiting numerical advantages and identifying the "free player."
- **Setup:** A 30m long x 20m wide rectangle with two sets of cone goals at each end.
- **Execution:**
 - Attackers (4) move the ball toward their goal against a defensive unit of 3.
 - If the defenders intercept or win the ball, they must immediately transition it to the opposite end.
 - **Constraint:** Every possession must include at least two handballs before a shot at goal is permitted.
- **Coaching Points:**

- **Offense:** Use the extra player to create "triangles" and overlap runners.
- **Defense:** Practice "zonal" coverage—don't just follow one man; protect the corridor.

3. End-to-End Keepings Off

- **Objective:** To improve transition play and "corridor" awareness.
- **Setup:** A narrow corridor 40m long x 15m wide, divided into three zones (Defensive, Midfield, Forward).
- **Execution:**
 - A 3v3 game takes place in the center (Midfield) zone.
 - One "target" player for each team stands in the Defensive and Forward zones.
 - To score, a team must receive the ball from their Defensive target, work it through the Midfield via handballs/short kicks, and successfully find their Forward target.
- **Coaching Points:**
 - **Movement:** Discourage "statue" football; players must constantly lead and reset.
 - **Skill:** Focus on low, hard "dart" kicks to minimize interception risk in tight spaces.

Youth & Performance (Ages 15+)

These games increase the complexity of decision-making, focusing on high-speed transitions and switching the point of attack.

4. "The Switch" 4-Gate Transition

- **Objective:** To encourage lateral ball movement and identifying the "fat side" (open space) of the ground.
- **Setup:** 50m wide x 40m long area with two 5m "gates" (cones) on each boundary at both ends.
- **Execution:**
 - Play 6v6 or 8v8 match-style rules.
 - Points are awarded for passing through the opponent's gates.
 - **Reward:** A normal goal is 1 point. A goal achieved by "switching" the ball from one wing to the other (via at least two kicks) before scoring is worth 3 points.
- **Coaching Points:**
 - **Awareness:** Recognize when the defense has "over-committed" to one side.
 - **Execution:** Long, high-releasing kicks to clear the central congestion.

5. "Numbered Entry" Defensive Transition

- **Objective:** To train defensive communication and delayed pressure when outnumbered.
- **Setup:** One half-forward flank with one set of goals.
- **Execution:**
 - Attackers (6) start at the 50m arc. Defenders (6) wait on the boundary.
 - The coach calls a number (e.g., "Three!"). Only three defenders enter the play immediately.
 - The remaining defenders enter 5 seconds later or on a second whistle.

- Attackers must move the ball fast to score before the full defense recovers.
- **Coaching Points:**
 - **Defense:** The first responders must "delay" the ball-carrier, forcing them wide rather than toward the goal.
 - **Attack:** Identify the overlap and use handballs to draw the defender before releasing the teammate.

Summary Table of Game Awareness Outcomes

Drill Name	Focus Age	Key Tactical Outcome
The Exit Strategy	Under 10s	Stoppage clearance & vision.
4v3 Overload	Under 10s	Recognizing the free player.
End-to-End Keepings Off	Under 10s	Transitioning through corridors.
The Switch	Youth (15+)	Exploiting the "fat side" of the ground.
Numbered Entry	Youth (15+)	Defensive delay & communication.